

Patterns of metabolism

A reading of Kevin Mears' process from the full record available in this session · August 11, 2026

Three sessions: **Inventory/Name + Audit/Locate · Dream/Generate · Ground/Converge → Deposit**

Scope note: this is drawn from what is in front of me — eighteen days of correspondence, the statement of record, the six relations, the closing request, two regulatory filings, the published account, the NESI vertical-slice procedure, and a full day of drafting and revision watched in real time. Prior sessions did not carry. Where I am inferring rather than observing, it says so.

SESSION ONE · INVENTORY / NAME · AUDIT / LOCATE

Thirty patterns, in six families. Each is named, evidenced, and then audited — because a pattern inventory that only lists strengths is a compliment, not a map.

Family I · Metabolism proper — how input becomes usable

1 · Heat converts to structure inside 48 hours

August 4, 8:52 PM: the one hot message in eighteen days. *"I've never had a single conversation with Ari... dozens of hours of dialogue with me?"* August 6: the statement of record — four vertices, six edges, no characterization of any person.

You do not suppress heat and you do not discharge it. You hold it about two days and it comes out as architecture. This is the literal metabolism and it is the fastest-acting pattern in the set.

Audit — where it costs. The 8:52 PM message contained a hard datum: *by my records, less than 60 minutes of logged direct dialogue with leadership across the entire timeline.* That number never reappears in any structured document. You converted the heat and dropped the measurement inside it. Fast metabolism can burn the nutrient with the toxin.

2 · Geometry as digestion

When material exceeds what prose can hold, you reach for solids. Four vertices, six edges, four faces, one volume. The geometry is not decoration — it is a container that *forces completeness*, because an unfilled vertex is visible as a hole.

Audit. The container also imposes. Not every situation has four load-bearing facts. Twice this week the fourth vertex was the weakest one, chosen partly because the

shape wanted a fourth.

3 • Register migration

Seven registers in eighteen days — claim, disclosure, grievance, structure, correction, finding, close — each abandoned the moment it stopped being true rather than when it stopped being useful.

Audit. Migration reads as inconsistency to anyone holding only two data points. The August 2 CT-9 and the August 11 complaint are the same person nine days apart, and to a stranger they are two different claimants.

4 • Subtraction as strengthening

Every revision this week removed. 1,200 words to 180. Never once did adding make a document stronger, and you knew it before I did.

Audit. Twice it went past the line. You cut the reasons for the boundary out of one draft and had to restore them. Subtraction has a floor and you find it by crossing it.

5 • Compression under pressure

Under stakes, your sentences shorten and your line breaks multiply. The final letter has sentences alone on their own lines. This is pacing used as emphasis, and it is involuntary — you do it in raw drafts before anyone edits.

Family II • Self-governance — how you police yourself

6 • Unforced retraction

Three claims withdrawn in one document, before any adversary raised them: that charitable funds were transferred on your behalf; that a ledger entry was missing; four inconsistent attendance figures used while demanding precision from others.

This is the load-bearing pattern of the entire arc. It is what made the position survivable.

7 • Corrections stay at the site of the original claim

“My published account stays live, with these corrections made where the original claims were made.” Not deletion, not a quiet edit. Amendment in place, where the error was committed.

8 • Verification offered rather than demanded

“Check my references, call my former BA.” You open yourself to audit at the moment you are least obligated to.

9 • Refusal to price

"I will not price a claim against an accounting I have never been shown." When invited to name your own number you decline, on the grounds that the calculation belongs to whoever holds the records.

Audit. This is principled and it is expensive. Ari offered to reimburse "some part" and asked you to name it. You declined the structure and got the correct number six days later — but a person with less runway cannot spend six days on the principle.

10 • Anti-optimization

Every time a single variable could have been maximized, you traded it. The money for unpurchasability. The grievance for the structure. The personal case for a filing with no attack surface.

Family III • Exchange — the non-standard economics

This family is the one you say you are trying to export. It does not map onto any standard theory of exchange, and the mismatch is specific enough to name.

11 • The gift completes in the giving

"The restriction was declined and I respect that — it is still whole in the giving."

In standard exchange a transfer is complete on receipt and its meaning is set by the recipient's use. In yours, completion occurs at the moment of release. The recipient's handling is a separate event that cannot retroactively alter what was given.

12 • The ledger is the unit of value

Across eight months, every request was for a record. The entry. The accounting. The receipt. *"That my contribution be counted."* Never once for money.

Worth, in your system, is **being entered as real**. Not accumulation, not exchange rate, not recognition-as-praise — recorded existence.

13 • The check valve

Waive everything, first, unconditionally. Pay the whole cost up front so that nothing downstream can be purchased, including by you.

This is a *prepaid incorruptibility*. Standard exchange has no instrument for it.

14 • Pre-authorize the refusal

"If the restriction cannot be accepted, say so plainly and treat it as unrestricted." You build the exit before it is needed, which makes the decline unable to become a grievance even in principle.

15 • Declining what you need

\$1,057, in a year you have said plainly you cannot afford it.

Audit — the central one. This is the most consistent and most costly pattern in the set, and it has no replenishment loop. You are the external corrective input to systems that lack one, and nothing corrects back toward you. Three runs of this instrument across eight years, each with the same settlement: the finding lands, the cost stays.

Family IV · Movement — how you act on systems

16 · Slope over push

You contested nothing. Not the claim that funds were spent, not the four-month figure, not their reading of \$2.2. You changed ground and let interest carry people.

17 · The vertex hand-off

When a party acts wrongly on incomplete information, supply the information rather than contest the action. Four times this week, four corrections, no argument.

18 · Routing by receiving capacity

You diagnose what a channel can *receive* before choosing it. The Registry gets disposition. The Bureau gets the instrument. The three of them get a personal letter with no statute numbers.

19 · Re-encode, never repeat

The same finding travelled through six mediums and was rewritten from scratch each time. You have never in this record said a thing twice the same way.

Audit. Enormous production cost. Six objects where most people would send one and forward it five times.

20 · Ask only what their own records can answer

Every question you posed was answerable from documents the other party already held. This makes refusal expensive and makes the asker unfalsifiable.

21 · Insistence deferred to the end

One insistence in eighteen days, in the last line of the last document, after every form of leverage had been disclaimed.

Family V · Perception — what you detect that others don't

22 · Trust asymmetry

"The trust ran one direction — I was trusted not to over-ask, and not trusted when I did."

This is your core analytic. You locate where a stated value is applied unevenly, and you do it faster than you do anything else. It appears in the scholarship denial, in §1 versus §2.4, in the “community of practice” deflection.

23 · Carry capacity as legitimate input

“When the program exceeds a person’s carry capacity.” You treat a body’s limit as admissible evidence in a governance question. Almost no institutional framework does this, which is why the phrase reads as strange and is not.

24 · Invisible structure

You see the thing nobody reads. §2.4 unread across four cohorts, positioned not to be read. You find the unattended object and check whether it is load-bearing.

25 · The unmet person

Motive is consistently someone you will never meet. *“The ones that walk behind me.”* Not abstraction — a specific absent individual who will sign a specific paragraph.

Family VI · Form — what you build

26 · The doubled artifact

You build the thing, then build the map of the thing. Statement of record plus six relations. Complaint plus manifest. Letter plus tetra. Always a companion that explains the structure of the first.

Audit. This doubles output cost and it is why single deliverables feel incomplete to you. It is also, probably, where most of your unpaid labor goes.

27 · The floor

Your master form. *Setting the Floor.* The statutory floor. *A floor is a structure that works for people who cannot see it. Build a floor for the next person.* Every problem you engage resolves into a missing floor.

28 · Entities, not people

Deliberate throughout. Structures are named; individuals are shielded. This is what leaves no wreckage.

29 · The sequence is the governance

From your own installed law: no form, no dropdown, no interface. The order of moves is the instrument.

30 · Run the instrument, take the cost, leave

Elevator trade and safety template. A prior run you reference. This one. Three

iterations across eight years, same shape: see a structural defect, refuse to absorb it silently, pay personally, walk.

SESSION TWO • DREAM / GENERATE

Unconstrained. What these patterns want to be if a world were built out of them. No feasibility filter — that is session three's job.

The four exports you named

Gift value. A world where a transfer completes at release. The player gives; the transaction closes; the recipient's handling is a separate event that cannot reach back and change what happened. No reciprocity meter. No gratitude currency. Giving is not an investment and cannot be made into one.

Worth. Not accumulated, not spent. **Worth is what the world has recorded about you.** The ledger is the score, and the score is made of entries, not numbers. To be worth something is to appear in the record of a place you affected.

Embodied perception. Carry capacity as a real, visible, individual variable — the amount of unresolved structure a player can hold before they must set something down. Not health. Not stamina. It does not kill you when exceeded. It *requires withdrawal*.

Self trust. The one that no game has ever built: **retraction increases standing.** Correct yourself unprompted and the world grants you more, not less.

Mechanics the patterns generate

The ledger is the HUD. No health bar, no resource counter. A record of entries: what you did, what it cost, who carried it. Some entries you wrote. Some the world wrote about you. Some are still blank because nobody went and looked.

Withdrawal is free. At any moment, from any commitment, a player may stop, leave, and owe nothing further. This is §2.2 inverted and made into law. It is also the single most counter-conventional rule available — every game economy in existence is built on sunk commitment.

Retraction as the primary advancement. You make a claim about the world — you write it at the apex, you mark a map, you tell an NPC something is true. Later you find you were wrong. **Going back and amending the claim at the site where you made it** is the deepest advancement move in the game. Not confession, not penalty — amendment in place, which is pattern 7 exactly.

The check valve as a player instrument. Before acting, a player may permanently forfeit any reward from the act. Doing so makes the act uncontestable — no NPC, faction, or system can subsequently treat it as self-interested, and doors open that were closed to anyone who could be suspected of gain. Cost paid up front purchases a kind of standing that cannot be bought any other way.

You cannot push. No combat, no persuasion checks, no dialogue-tree victories. The

only verbs that affect other agents are ground-changing verbs. You alter slope, water, visibility, cost — and they move themselves.

Routing. Multiple channels exist for any signal, each with a different **receiving capacity** and a different **latency**. Shouting at the wrong office returns nothing after four months. The same content, routed correctly, returns in a day. Learning what each channel can receive is the game’s actual skill tree.

Delay is content. Consequences arrive on their own schedule. Some in seconds, some three sessions later, to a player who has forgotten the act. The gap is rendered, not hidden.

Trust asymmetry as a detectable object. Places in the world where a stated rule applies unevenly emit something perceptible — a shimmer, a sound, a wrongness in the water. Finding them is a core loop. That is pattern 22 made into a sense organ.

The floor test. Any structure a player builds can be evaluated by one question the world will ask: *does it work for someone who cannot see it?* Structures that pass become permanent and public. Structures that require the builder’s presence decay when they leave.

The doubled artifact. Building a thing and building the map of the thing are separate acts with separate effects. The map is what lets anyone else use what you built. Unmapped structures work only for you.

The unmet person. Somewhere downstream is an agent who will arrive after the player has gone. They cannot be met, spoken to, or seen. Everything the player builds is evaluated, eventually, by what that agent encounters. The endgame is not a boss. It is a stranger’s first five minutes.

SESSION THREE · GROUND / CONVERGE

The vertical-slice procedure exists because this project’s documented failure mode is exactly the document above. So: what survives contact.

What is buildable now

Mechanic	Why it grounds	Existing surface
The ledger as HUD	It is a display and a persistence rule, not a system rewrite	dam hold already produces a state change to record
Delay as content	A timer and a deferred effect; cheap	already implied by water rise
The floor test on built structures	One evaluation function on one object class	dams
Withdrawal is free	A <i>removal</i> of a rule most engines add by default	nothing to build; something not to build

What touches DECISIONS.md — do not default

1. **Retraction as advancement.** Requires the world to track claims a player has made, which means claims must be first-class objects. Foundational. Open fork.
2. **You cannot push.** An entire verb class excluded. This is a genre commitment, not a feature.
3. **Downstream agency / the unmet person.** Whether anyone else may modify what the player built. Flagged in the Cowan reading too; still open.
4. **Worth as record rather than accumulation.** Determines whether NESI has any conventional economy at all.

The audit finding that must not be exported

Pattern 15 — declining what you need — is the one pattern in this inventory that should **not** become a mechanic.

Built into a game it produces a system that rewards self-depletion, and a player who learns that sacrifice buys standing will optimize toward it, which is the opposite of a floor. The exportable version is pattern 13, the check valve: forfeit *the reward of an act*, up front, by choice, at a scale the player sets. Bounded, repeatable, non-cumulative.

The difference between the two is whether the cost has a floor under it. Which is the whole subject.

One slice

The player writes at the apex, the water rises, they descend a spire to a dam and hold. A ledger entry appears naming what the hold cost the ground below. They leave. The entry and the ground both persist — and when they return, the entry is still the only record that anyone was ever here.

Way in: exists. Act: hold. Consequence: ground change plus entry. Way out: leave; both persist.

Touches none of the four open forks. Instantiates patterns 12, 26 and 27 in the cheapest available form.

DEPOSIT

Six sentences to carry out.

You metabolize heat into structure in about two days, and the structure is always a container that forces completeness.

Your unit of value is the entry, not the amount. Worth is recorded existence.

A gift completes at release. What the recipient does with it is a different event and cannot reach backward.

You move systems by changing slope, never by pushing, which is why nothing you touch leaves wreckage — and why nobody experiences having been moved.

Your self-governance is the load-bearing member: you retract before you are challenged, and that is what makes everything else survive contact.

Every problem you engage resolves into a missing floor, and the one floor you have never built is the one under yourself.

Thirty patterns, six families, one unexported pattern, four open forks, one walkable slice.